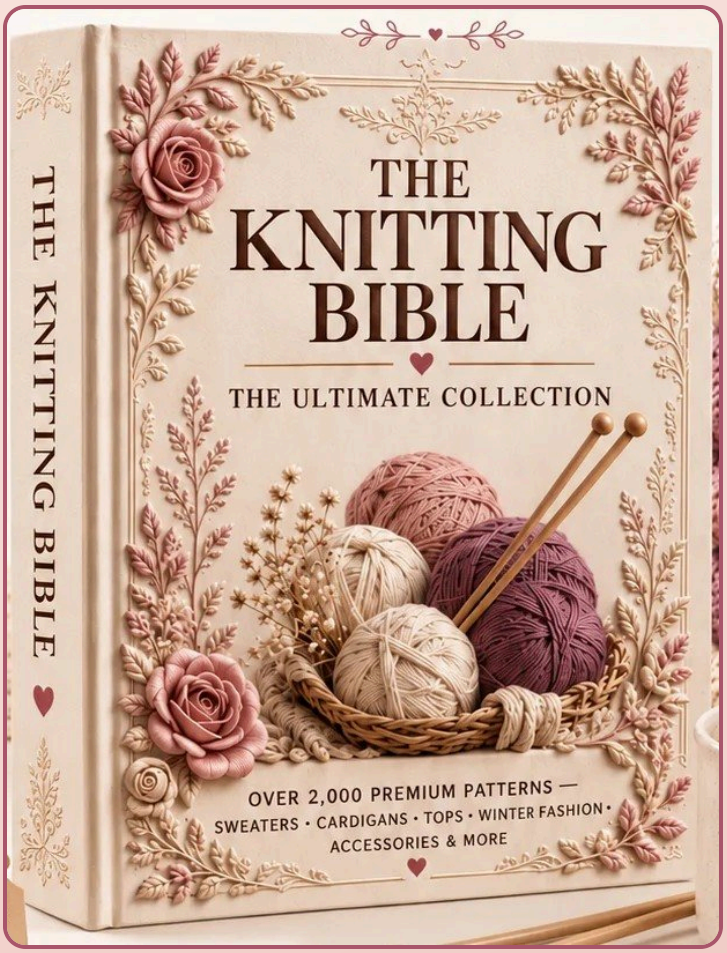
BONUS 7

Crochet and Patterns Guide

Essential crochet stitches, clearly explained



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Next step

> *Crochet is one of the friendliest crafts you can pick up. All you need is a hook, some yarn, and a little patience, and within an afternoon you can make a fabric with your own hands. This guide teaches the essential stitches one at a time, explains how to read a crochet pattern, gives you twelve easy stitch patterns with exact stitch counts, and walks you through eight beginner projects. Work through it in order, keep a small practice swatch going, and do not worry if your first rows look wobbly. Everyone's first rows do.*

Before you start

Crochet hooks are blunt, but scissors, tapestry needles, and pins are sharp, so cut and pin with care. Take stretch breaks every 20 to 30 minutes to protect your hands and wrists. Small pieces, loose ends, and buttons are choking hazards for babies, toddlers, and pets, so keep them out of reach and never leave a child or pet alone with a finished piece. Wash and dry your yarn as the ball band directs.

1. Welcome to Crochet

Crochet builds fabric from loops. You make one loop, pull another loop through it, and repeat. Unlike knitting, you only ever have one live loop on the hook at a time, which makes it easy to stop, put your work down, and pick it up again. It also makes mistakes easy to fix, because you can pull out a few stitches without losing everything.

Here is how this guide is organized. Sections 2 through 5 cover tools, holding the hook, the slip knot, and the chain. Sections 6 through 12 teach the basic stitches and how to work into the foundation chain. Sections 13 through 18 cover reading patterns, rows and rounds, increases and decreases, loops, color changes, and fixing mistakes. Sections 19 and 20 cover gauge and finishing. Then you get the stitch library, eight projects, a troubleshooting table, and a 14-day practice plan.

- **Practice yarn:** choose a smooth, light-colored worsted weight yarn so you can see every stitch.
- **Practice hook:** a 5.5 mm (US I-9) hook is a comfortable starting size.
- **Time:** 20 to 30 minutes a day beats one long session each week.

2. Tools and Materials

You do not need a lot to begin. A few well-chosen tools make the learning curve gentler.

Your starter kit

- **Crochet hooks** in a few sizes. Aluminum hooks are slick and fast, wood or bamboo hooks grip the yarn, and ergonomic handles help tired hands.
- **Yarn:** one or two balls of worsted weight yarn in a plain color. Cotton is sturdy for dishcloths, and acrylic or wool blends are good for general practice.
- **Scissors** small enough to carry in your project bag.
- **Tapestry needle** with a large eye and a blunt tip for weaving in ends.
- **Stitch markers** (or safety pins or scraps of contrasting yarn) to mark the start of a round or a corner.
- **Measuring tape or ruler** for gauge and sizing.

- **Rust-proof pins** and a flat surface for blocking.

Hook sizes

Hooks are sold with a US letter or number and a metric size in millimeters. The millimeter size is the one that matters, because letters and numbers vary by maker. The table lists the common sizes.

US SIZE	METRIC (MM)	TYPICALLY USED FOR
B-1	2.25	Fine thread, lace, tiny toys
C-2	2.75	Fingering yarn, lace
D-3	3.25	Fingering and sport yarn
E-4	3.5	Sport yarn, small toys
F-5	3.75	Sport and DK yarn
G-6	4.0	DK yarn, baby items
7	4.5	DK and light worsted yarn
H-8	5.0	Light worsted, tight stitches
I-9	5.5	Worsted weight, beginner favorite
J-10	6.0	Worsted weight, drapey fabric
K-10.5	6.5	Worsted and bulky yarn
L-11	8.0	Bulky yarn
M/N-13	9.0	Super bulky yarn
N/P-15	10.0	Super bulky and jumbo yarn

Yarn weights

Yarn is grouped into numbered weights. The ball band shows the number and a suggested hook range. Treat the range as a starting point and let your swatch decide.

WEIGHT NUMBER	NAME	SUGGESTED HOOK (MM)	COMMON USES
1	Super fine (fingering)	2.25 to 3.5	Socks, shawls, lace
2	Fine (sport)	3.5 to 4.5	Baby items, light garments
3	Light (DK)	4.5 to 5.5	Garments, baby blankets
4	Medium (worsted)	5.5 to 6.5	Blankets, hats, dishcloths, most beginner projects

WEIGHT NUMBER	NAME	SUGGESTED HOOK (MM)	COMMON USES
5	Bulky	6.5 to 9.0	Scarves, quick hats, rugs
6	Super bulky	9.0 to 15.0	Chunky throws, thick scarves

Matching hook to yarn

A hook that is too small makes stiff, tight fabric that is hard to work into. A hook that is too large makes loose, holey fabric. As a rule of thumb, start with the hook size on the ball band. If your fabric feels stiff, go up a size. If it looks gappy or floppy, go down a size. Projects that should hold their shape, like baskets, use a smaller hook than the band suggests. Projects that should drape, like shawls, use a larger one.

> **Smooth yarn is your friend**
>
> Light colors and smooth plied yarns make stitches easy to see. Avoid dark, fuzzy, or textured yarns until you are comfortable finding the loops.

3. Holding the Hook and the Yarn

There is no single correct grip. What matters is that your hands are relaxed and that the yarn flows with even tension. Try both of the common hook holds and keep the one that feels natural.

- **Pencil grip:** hold the hook like a pencil, with your thumb and index finger on the flat thumb rest.
- **Knife grip:** hold the hook like a table knife, with your palm over the handle and your fingers wrapped around it.

For the yarn, your non-hook hand controls tension. Pass the yarn between your pinky and ring finger, over the ring and middle fingers, then under your index finger. Your index finger lifts the yarn up to the hook, and your thumb and middle finger pinch the work close to the hook so the stitch you are making stays steady.

When you are just learning, expect your tension to change from row to row. That is normal. It evens out as the motions turn into habit, usually within the first few projects.

4. The Slip Knot

Every piece of crochet starts with a slip knot on the hook. It is the first loop.

1. Leave a tail of about 6 inches (15 cm) and make a loop by crossing the yarn over itself.
2. Reach through the loop and pull up a loop of the working yarn (the yarn attached to the ball).
3. Put that new loop on your hook.
4. Pull on both the tail and the working yarn to snug the loop up against the hook. It should slide freely but not be loose.

If the loop will not move on the hook, you made it too tight. Loosen it slightly, because the first chain stitches must be able to pass over the hook easily.

5. The Chain Stitch (ch)

The chain is the foundation of almost everything. A row of chains is called a foundation chain, and you work your first row of stitches into it.

1. Hold the slip knot on the hook and the tail in your non-hook hand.
2. Wrap the working yarn over the hook from back to front. This is called a yarn over (yo).
3. Pull the hook, with the yarn on it, through the loop on the hook. You have made one chain.
4. Repeat until you have the number of chains you need.

Count your chains as you go. The loop on the hook is never counted. Each V-shaped stitch on the front of the chain is one chain, and the bumps on the back are the loops you will sometimes work into.

> **Practice goal**
> Chain 30 stitches, count them, then pull the chain out and do it again. Aim for chains that are all the same size, with the hook sliding in easily.

6. The Slip Stitch (sl st)

The slip stitch is the shortest stitch. You use it to join rounds, move along the top of a row without adding height, and finish edges.

1. Insert the hook into the stitch or chain indicated.
2. Yarn over.
3. Pull the yarn through both the stitch and the loop on your hook in one motion.

To practice, chain 20 and slip stitch into the second chain from the hook and each chain across. You should end with one loop on the hook.

7. The Single Crochet (sc)

The single crochet makes a dense, sturdy fabric. It is the best stitch to learn first because it is short and easy to control.

1. Insert the hook into the stitch indicated.
2. Yarn over and pull up a loop. You now have two loops on the hook.
3. Yarn over and pull through both loops. One loop remains. You have made one single crochet.

At the end of a row, chain 1 and turn your work so the other side faces you. The chain 1 is a turning chain. It lifts the yarn to the height of the next row and does not count as a stitch in single crochet.

> **Check your count**
>
> After every row, count your stitches. If you started with 20 single crochets, you should have 20 at the end of every row. The turning chain is not one of them.

8. The Half Double Crochet (hdc)

The half double crochet is a little taller than single crochet and works up faster. It makes a soft, flexible fabric with a slightly ribbed look.

1. Yarn over, then insert the hook into the stitch indicated.
2. Yarn over and pull up a loop. You now have three loops on the hook.
3. Yarn over and pull through all three loops. You have made one half double crochet.

Turn each row with chain 2. In the patterns in this guide, that chain 2 does not count as a stitch, so you work your first hdc into the very first stitch of the row.

9. The Double Crochet (dc)

The double crochet is the most common stitch in crochet. It is tall, fast, and the building block of granny squares, shells, and most blankets.

1. Yarn over, then insert the hook into the stitch indicated.
2. Yarn over and pull up a loop. You now have three loops on the hook.
3. Yarn over and pull through two loops. Two loops remain.
4. Yarn over and pull through the last two loops. You have made one double crochet.

Turn each row of double crochet with chain 3. In this guide the chain 3 counts as the first double crochet of the next row, so you skip the first stitch of the row below and work your first real dc into the second stitch. At the end of the row, work your last dc into the top of the turning chain from the previous row.

10. The Treble Crochet (tr)

The treble crochet is taller still. It makes an airy fabric and is useful for lacy stitch patterns.

1. Yarn over twice, then insert the hook into the stitch indicated.
2. Yarn over and pull up a loop. You now have four loops on the hook.
3. Yarn over and pull through two loops. Three loops remain.
4. Yarn over and pull through two loops. Two loops remain.
5. Yarn over and pull through the last two loops.

Turn each row of treble crochet with chain 4. The chain 4 counts as the first treble of the next row.

Turning chains at a glance

STITCH	TURNING CHAIN	COUNTS AS A STITCH?	FIRST STITCH OF THE FOUNDATION ROW GOES IN
Single crochet (sc)	Chain 1	No	2nd chain from hook
Half double crochet (hdc)	Chain 2	No (in this guide)	3rd chain from hook
Double crochet (dc)	Chain 3	Yes	4th chain from hook
Treble crochet (tr)	Chain 4	Yes	5th chain from hook

Some patterns count the hdc turning chain as a stitch and some do not. Always read the pattern notes. In this guide, the hdc chain 2 never counts.

11. Working Into the Foundation Chain

Your first row is worked into the foundation chain. Each stitch goes into one chain, starting from the end near the hook. Skipped chains at the start take the place of the turning chain.

STITCH	CHAINS TO MAKE	STITCHES YOU GET IN ROW 1
Single crochet	Stitches wanted + 1	Chains minus 1
Half double crochet	Stitches wanted + 2	Chains minus 2
Double crochet (skipped chains count as 1 dc)	Stitches wanted + 2	Chains minus 2
Treble crochet (skipped chains count as 1 tr)	Stitches wanted + 3	Chains minus 3

For example, to make a row of 20 single crochets, chain 21, skip the first chain (the one nearest the hook), and work into the second chain from the hook. To make a row of 20 double crochets, chain 22, skip the first three chains (they count as the first dc), and work your next dc into the fourth chain from the hook. That gives 1 + 19 = 20 stitches.

Which loops to work into

The chain has a V on the front and a bump on the back. Working through the back bump only gives a neat, stable edge that you can later work into for a border. Working under the top two strands of the V is faster and easier for beginners. Either is fine. Pick one and use it consistently on a project.

The stitch top

Every stitch has a V on top made of two loops, the front loop (the one closer to you) and the back loop (the one farther away). Unless a pattern says otherwise, insert your hook under both loops.

12. Rows and Turning

When you finish a row, you turn the work like a page in a book. That swaps which side faces you. The side that faces you on row 1 is usually called the right side (RS), and the other side is the wrong side (WS). It is easiest to always turn in the same direction, which prevents the edges from twisting.

- **Edges:** the first and last stitch of a row set the edge. If your edges wander in and out, count your stitches.
- **Marking row 1:** clip a stitch marker or a scrap of yarn to the first row so you can count rows later.
- **Counting rows:** for double crochet, count the turning chains up the edge. For single crochet, count the horizontal bars along the edge.

13. Reading Crochet Patterns

Crochet patterns are written in a compact shorthand, but the code is small and easy to learn. This guide uses US terms, which are the standard for patterns written in American English. UK terms use the same names for different stitches, so always check which set a pattern uses.

US TERM	UK TERM
Single crochet (sc)	Double crochet (dc)
Half double crochet (hdc)	Half treble (htr)
Double crochet (dc)	Treble (tr)
Treble crochet (tr)	Double treble (dtr)
Gauge	Tension

Common abbreviations

ABBREVIATION	MEANING
ch	chain
sl st	slip stitch
sc	single crochet
hdc	half double crochet
dc	double crochet
tr	treble crochet
st(s)	stitch(es)
sp	space
sk	skip

ABBREVIATION	MEANING
inc	increase (2 stitches in the same stitch)
dec	decrease (2 stitches worked together)
sc2tog	single crochet 2 stitches together
yo	yarn over
rep	repeat
rnd	round
RS / WS	right side / wrong side
BLO / FLO	back loop only / front loop only
FPdc / BPdc	front post double crochet / back post double crochet
MR	magic ring
beg	beginning

Asterisks, brackets, and parentheses

- **Asterisks (*)** mark the start of a repeat. 'Rep from *' means do everything after the asterisk again. 'Rep from * 5 more times' means the section is worked 6 times in total: once plus five repeats.
- **Brackets [ ]** hold a group of steps to repeat a stated number of times, such as [sc in next st, inc in next st] 4 times.
- **Parentheses ( )** hold stitches that all go into the same stitch or space, such as (3 dc, ch 2, 3 dc) in the corner.
- **A number in parentheses at the end of a row** is the stitch count you should have, such as (30 sts).

A worked example

Suppose a round reads: **Sc in next 3 sts, inc in next st; rep from * 5 more times. (30 sts).* Each repeat uses 4 stitches from the round below (3 sc plus the stitch you increase in) and makes 3 + 2 = 5 stitches. Six repeats give 6 x 5 = 30 stitches, and the round below must have had 6 x 4 = 24 stitches. If your count does not match, find the error before going further.

> **Read it all first**
>
> Read the whole pattern, including the notes on gauge, turning chains, and finishing, before you make the first stitch. Highlight your size if there are several.

14. Working in Rows and in the Round

Flat rows

Rows go back and forth. You turn at the end of each row, chain the turning chain, and work across the stitches of the row below. Rows make scarves, blankets, dishcloths, and anything flat.

Rounds

Rounds go in a circle, so you never turn. The right side always faces you. Rounds make hats, coasters, baskets, and toys. In joined rounds you end with a slip stitch into the first stitch. In spiral rounds you do not join at all and simply keep going, using a marker to track the start.

The magic ring

The magic ring (MR) is an adjustable loop that lets you start a round with no hole in the middle.

1. Wrap the yarn around two fingers to make a loop, with the tail across the front.
2. Insert the hook into the loop, yarn over, and pull up a loop from the working yarn.
3. Chain 1 to lock the ring. This chain does not count as a stitch.
4. Work your first round of stitches into the ring, over both strands (the loop and the tail).
5. When the round is done, pull the tail to close the ring, then pull the tail tight and secure it.

> **No magic ring yet?**
> Chain 4 and join with a slip stitch into the first chain to make a small ring. Work the first round into the center of the ring. It leaves a small hole, which is fine for a basket or coaster.

Joining a round

At the end of a joined round, insert the hook into the first stitch of the round (or the top of the beginning chain) and slip stitch. Then chain for the turning height of the next round: 1 for sc, 2 for hdc, 3 for dc. In this guide, the sc and hdc chains do not count as stitches. The dc chain 3 does.

A circle in single crochet

A flat circle in single crochet always follows the same rule: round 1 has 6 stitches, and every following round has 6 more than the one before it. So round 2 has 12, round 3 has 18, round 4 has 24, and round n has 6 x n stitches. To get to a stitch count, work (sc in next n − 2 sts, inc) six times. For round 5, that is 6 x (3 + 2) = 30 stitches, because n − 2 = 3.

15. Increases and Decreases

Increases make your work wider. Decreases make it narrower. You use them to shape hats, toys, and garments.

Increase (inc)

Work two stitches into the same stitch. That is one extra stitch. In single crochet it reads 'inc' or '2 sc in next st'.

Decrease (dec)

Work two stitches together. For a single crochet decrease (sc2tog):

1. Insert the hook into the next stitch, yarn over, and pull up a loop. You have two loops on the hook.
2. Insert the hook into the following stitch, yarn over, and pull up a loop. You have three loops on the hook.
3. Yarn over and pull through all three loops. Two stitches are now one.

The invisible decrease

This decrease sits flatter and is nearly invisible, which is perfect for hats and toys.

1. Insert the hook through the front loop only of the next stitch.
2. Insert the hook through the front loop only of the stitch after it. You now have two loops on the hook, plus the loop already on it.
3. Yarn over and pull through the two front loops. Two loops remain on the hook.
4. Yarn over and pull through both loops.

> **Spread them out**
>
> When shaping, spread increases or decreases evenly around a round rather than stacking them in the same spot. Stacked increases make a visible point on a circle. Staggering them keeps the shape smooth.

16. Working in the Back Loop or Front Loop Only

Every stitch top has two loops. When a pattern says BLO, insert your hook under the back loop only. The front loop stays behind as a visible bar. When it says FLO, insert under the front loop only.

- **Single crochet worked in BLO every row:** makes a stretchy, ribbed fabric that looks like knitting. It is great for hat brims, headbands, and cuffs.
- **BLO on one round:** makes a ridge. Use it for the corner at the bottom of a basket.
- **FLO:** leaves the back loop free for later work, such as adding a decorative ruffle.

Fabric worked in BLO is stretchier than fabric worked in both loops, so you may need fewer stitches for a snug fit.

17. Changing Colors

Change colors during the last yarn over of the final stitch before the new color. That means you complete the stitch with the new color, so the join sits neatly.

1. Work the last stitch of the old color until two loops remain (for sc, that is when you have pulled up the loop).

2. Drop the old yarn and pick up the new color.
3. Yarn over with the new color and pull it through the final two loops.
4. Continue with the new color. Leave tails of at least 4 inches (10 cm) on both yarns.

- **Carrying the yarn:** for stripes of two rows, you can carry the unused color loosely up the side. Do not pull it tight, or the edge will pucker.
- **Cutting the yarn:** for wider stripes, cut the old color, leaving a tail, and weave it in later.
- **In the round:** change at the end of the round before the slip stitch, and begin the new round with the new color.

If you do not mind a jog at the start of a joined round, simply keep going. For a clean look, many crocheters work in a spiral and change color right at the marker.

18. Fixing Mistakes

You will make mistakes. It is part of learning, and every crocheter does it. The fix is usually easier than you think.

Frogging (ripping back)

Remove the hook from the loop, gently pull the working yarn, and the stitches unravel. Stop when you reach the row you want, then slide the hook back into the last good loop. If your yarn is fuzzy, pull gently. To avoid losing the loop, take the hook out only when you are ready to rip.

Lifelines

Thread a smooth contrasting yarn through the stitches of a good row. If you must rip back, you can unravel to the lifeline and it will hold the stitches for you.

Counting to find an error

- Count your stitches at the end of every row. If a row has too few, you probably skipped the last stitch or the turning chain.
- If a row has too many, you probably worked twice into the same stitch or counted a turning chain that should not count.
- To find a missed stitch, hold the work up to the light and look for a gap or a place where stitches lean.

Common slips

PROBLEM	WHY IT HAPPENS	HOW TO FIX IT
Edges get wider	Extra stitches at the turn	Do not work into the turning chain unless told to; count every row
Edges get narrower	Skipped the last stitch	Look for the turning chain from the row below and work into it

PROBLEM	WHY IT HAPPENS	HOW TO FIX IT
Twisted foundation chain	Chain was twisted when you started row 1	Lay the chain flat before working the first row

19. Gauge and Swatching

Gauge is the number of stitches and rows in a set square of fabric, usually 4 inches (10 cm). Two people using the same pattern, hook, and yarn can get different sizes, so a gauge swatch tells you how your hands crochet.

How to swatch

1. Use the yarn and hook the pattern calls for.
2. Work a swatch at least 6 inches (15 cm) square in the pattern stitch.
3. Lay it flat without stretching. Block it the same way you will block the finished item, then let it dry.
4. Measure 4 inches (10 cm) across the middle with a ruler and count the stitches and rows inside.

Reading the result

YOUR SWATCH	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT TO DO
More stitches than the pattern in 4 inches	Your stitches are too small	Go up one hook size
Fewer stitches than the pattern in 4 inches	Your stitches are too large	Go down one hook size
Matches the pattern	Great	Start the project

To turn gauge into a stitch count, divide the stitches by 4 and multiply by the width you want. Example: if 14 sc equal 4 inches, then 8 inches needs 14 / 4 x 8 = 28 sc. Rows work the same way: if 16 rows equal 4 inches, 8 inches needs 16 / 4 x 8 = 32 rows.

> **Gauge matters most for fitted items**
>
> For dishcloths, blankets, and baskets, small size differences hardly matter. For hats, sweaters, and anything that must fit, gauge is worth the extra time.

20. Finishing

Weaving in ends

Cut the yarn, leaving a tail of about 6 inches (15 cm), and pull it through the last loop to fasten off. Thread the tail on a tapestry needle and weave it through the stitches along the back of the work for at least 2 inches (5 cm), then reverse direction for another inch (2.5 cm). Trim the end close to the fabric.

Blocking

Blocking evens out stitches and sets the shape. For acrylic yarn, steam from a distance without touching the fabric, because heat can flatten it permanently. For wool and cotton, wet the piece, press out water with a towel, then pin it to the right size on a flat surface and let it dry.

Joining pieces

- **Slip stitch seam:** hold the pieces together with right sides facing and slip stitch through both layers. It makes a firm, visible ridge.
- **Whip stitch:** use a tapestry needle to sew through the back loops of both pieces. It makes a flat seam.
- **Mattress stitch:** sew along the edges from the right side for a nearly invisible seam.
- **Single crochet seam:** with the pieces together, work single crochet through both layers. It is quick and sturdy.

21. A Library of 12 Stitch Patterns

Each pattern below gives the exact multiple, the foundation chain, and the rows. Use them for scarves, blankets, or swatches. Each pattern includes a sample size you can try. Use a worsted weight yarn and a 5.5 mm (US I-9) hook for all swatches.

> **How to read the counts**
> The multiple tells you how many stitches you need for the pattern repeat to fit. The foundation chain includes the extra chains for the turning or the first stitch. Stitch counts are listed after rows so you can check your work.

1. Single Crochet Fabric

Multiple: any number of stitches. **Foundation chain:** stitches + 1. Sample: chain 21 for 20 sc..

1. Sc in 2nd ch from hook and in each ch across. (20 sc)
2. Ch 1, turn. Sc in each st across. (20 sc)
3. Repeat row 2.

Check: every row has 20 sc.

2. Extended Single Crochet

Multiple: any number of stitches. **Foundation chain:** stitches + 1. Sample: chain 21 for 20 esc..

1. Esc in 2nd ch from hook and in each ch across. To make an esc: insert the hook, yarn over and pull up a loop, yarn over and pull through the first loop only (that is the extra chain), yarn over and pull through both remaining loops. (20 esc)
2. Ch 1, turn. Esc in each st across. (20 esc)
3. Repeat row 2.

Check: every row has 20 esc.

3. Half Double Crochet

Multiple: any number of stitches. **Foundation chain:** stitches + 2. Sample: chain 22 for 20 hdc..

1. Hdc in 3rd ch from hook and in each ch across. (20 hdc)
2. Ch 2 (does not count), turn. Hdc in each st across. (20 hdc)
3. Repeat row 2.

Check: every row has 20 hdc.

4. Double Crochet

Multiple: any number of stitches. **Foundation chain:** stitches + 2. Sample: chain 22 for 20 dc..

1. Dc in 4th ch from hook (skipped chs count as first dc) and in each ch across. (20 dc)
2. Ch 3 (counts as first dc), turn. Skip first st, dc in each st across, ending with dc in top of turning ch. (20 dc)
3. Repeat row 2.

Check: every row has 20 dc, counting the turning chain as the first.

5. Treble Crochet Fabric

Multiple: any number of stitches. **Foundation chain:** stitches + 3. Sample: chain 23 for 20 tr..

1. Tr in 5th ch from hook (skipped chs count as first tr) and in each ch across. (20 tr)
2. Ch 4 (counts as first tr), turn. Skip first st, tr in each st across, ending with tr in top of turning ch. (20 tr)
3. Repeat row 2.

Check: every row has 20 tr, counting the turning chain as the first.

6. Ribbed Single Crochet (BLO)

Multiple: any number of stitches. **Foundation chain:** stitches + 1. Sample: chain 21 for 20 sc..

1. Sc in 2nd ch from hook and in each ch across. (20 sc)
2. Ch 1, turn. Sc in back loop only of each st across. (20 sc)
3. Repeat row 2. The ridges form on the side facing you in rows worked on the wrong side.

Check: every row has 20 sc. This fabric stretches widthwise, so it suits headbands and cuffs.

7. Seed (Moss) Stitch

Multiple: a multiple of 2 stitches. **Foundation chain:** stitches + 1. Sample: chain 21 for 20 sts..

1. Sc in 2nd ch from hook, dc in next ch, *sc in next ch, dc in next ch; rep from * across. (10 sc and 10 dc = 20 sts)

2. Ch 1, turn. *Sc in next dc, dc in next sc; rep from * across. (10 sc and 10 dc = 20 sts)
3. Repeat row 2. Always work sc into dc and dc into sc, so the stitches alternate row by row.

Check: every row has 20 sts. Ch 1 is not counted.

8. Waffle Check

Multiple: an odd number of stitches. **Foundation chain:** stitches + 2. Sample: chain 23 for 21 dc..

1. Dc in 4th ch from hook and in each ch across. (21 dc)
2. Row A (post row): Ch 2 (does not count), turn. Dc in first st, *FPdc around next st, dc in next st; rep from * across, ending with dc in top of turning ch. (10 fpdc and 11 dc = 21 sts)
3. Row B: Ch 2 (does not count), turn. Dc in first 2 sts, *FPdc around next st, dc in next st; rep from * 8 more times (9 times in all), dc in last st. (9 fpdc and 12 dc = 21 sts)
4. Repeat rows A and B. To make a front post double crochet: yarn over, insert the hook from front to back to front around the post of the stitch below, then finish like a dc.

Check: every row has 21 sts. Alternating rows A and B shifts the raised posts to build a waffle texture.

9. Shell Stitch

Multiple: a multiple of 6 stitches + 1 (sample: 3 repeats = 19 sts). **Foundation chain:** 6 x repeats + 2. Sample: chain 20 for 3 shells..

1. Sc in 2nd ch from hook, *sk 2 chs, 5 dc in next ch, sk 2 chs, sc in next ch; rep from * across. (4 sc and 3 shells of 5 dc = 4 + 15 = 19 sts)
2. Ch 3 (counts as first dc), turn. 2 dc in first sc, *sk 2 dc, sc in next dc (center of shell), sk 2 dc, 5 dc in next sc; rep from * ending with last repeat: sk 2 dc, sc in next dc, sk 2 dc, 3 dc in last sc. (3 dc at each end and 2 shells of 5 dc plus 3 sc: 3 + 3 + 10 + 3 = 19 sts)
3. Ch 1, turn. Sc in first dc, *sk 2 dc, 5 dc in next sc, sk 2 dc, sc in next dc; rep from * across, ending with the final sc in top of turning ch. (4 sc and 3 shells = 19 sts)
4. Repeat rows 2 and 3.

Check: rows 1 and 3 have 4 sc and 3 shells (19 sts). Row 2 has 3 dc at each end, 3 sc, and 2 full shells (19 sts).

10. Bean Stitch

Multiple: an odd number of stitches. **Foundation chain:** stitches + 1. Sample: chain 22 for 21 sts..

1. Row 1 (right side): Sc in 2nd ch from hook and in each ch across. (21 sc)
2. Row 2 (bean row, wrong side): Ch 1, turn. Sc in first st, *bean in next st, sc in next st; rep from * across. (11 sc and 10 beans = 21 sts)
3. Row 3: Ch 1, turn. Sc in each st across, working one sc in the top of each bean. (21 sc)
4. Repeat rows 2 and 3. A bean is a 3-dc bobble: *yarn over, insert the hook in the st, yarn over, pull up a loop, yarn over and pull through 2 loops*, work this 3 times in the same stitch (4 loops on the hook), then yarn over and pull through all 4 loops.

Check: every row has 21 sts. The beans sit on the wrong side of the work and pop to the right side.

11. Puff Stitch

Multiple: an odd number of stitches. **Foundation chain:** stitches + 1. Sample: chain 22 for 21 sts..

1. Row 1 (right side): Sc in 2nd ch from hook and in each ch across. (21 sc)
2. Row 2 (puff row, wrong side): Ch 1, turn. Sc in first st, *puff in next st, sc in next st; rep from * across. (11 sc and 10 puffs = 21 sts)
3. Row 3: Ch 1, turn. Sc in each st across, working one sc in the top of each puff. (21 sc)
4. Repeat rows 2 and 3. To make a puff: *yarn over, insert the hook in the st, yarn over and pull up a loop*, work this 3 times in the same stitch (7 loops on the hook), yarn over and pull through all 7 loops. Close the top with a tight sc in the next stitch.

Check: every row has 21 sts. Keep the puff loops loose so the hook can pass through them.

12. Sc and Dc Stripes

Multiple: any number of stitches. **Foundation chain:** stitches + 1. Sample: chain 21 for 20 sts..

1. Sc in 2nd ch from hook and in each ch across. (20 sc)
2. Ch 3 (counts as first dc), turn. Skip first st, dc in each st across. (20 sts: ch 3 plus 19 dc)
3. Ch 1, turn. Sc in each dc across and in top of turning ch. (20 sc)
4. Repeat rows 2 and 3.

Check: every row has 20 sts. Change color at the end of each row for neat stripes.

22. Eight Beginner Projects

Each project lists materials, gauge, and steps, with every stitch count checked. Work the gauge swatch first. If your gauge is off, try a different hook size rather than changing the pattern.

PROJECT SAFETY

☐ Weave in all ends securely.

☐ Keep small pieces away from babies, toddlers, and pets.

☐ Wash cotton items on a gentle cycle and dry flat.

☐ Never leave a baby alone with a blanket or put one in a sleep space. Follow current safe sleep guidance from your pediatrician.

Project 1: Dishcloth

Materials: about 40 yards (37 m) of worsted weight cotton, 5.5 mm (US I-9) hook, tapestry needle. **Gauge:** 14 sc and 16 rows = 4 inches (10 cm) in single crochet. **Finished size:** about 8 inches (20 cm) square.

1. Chain 29.

2. Row 1: Sc in 2nd ch from hook and in each ch across. (28 sc)
3. Rows 2 to 32: Ch 1, turn. Sc in each st across. (28 sc)
4. Check: 28 sts at 14 sts per 4 inches is 8 inches wide, and 32 rows at 16 rows per 4 inches is 8 inches tall.
5. Fasten off and weave in the ends.

For a scrubby texture, work every row in the back loop only. Wash a new cloth before its first use.

Project 2: Round Coaster

Materials: about 15 yards (14 m) of worsted weight cotton, 5.5 mm (US I-9) hook. **Gauge:** same as the dishcloth. **Finished size:** about 4.5 inches (11 cm) across.

1. Round 1: Make a magic ring. Work 6 sc into the ring. Join with sl st to the first sc. (6 sts)
2. Round 2: Ch 1. Inc in each st around. (12 sts)
3. Round 3: Ch 1. *Sc in next st, inc in next st; rep from * 5 more times. (18 sts)
4. Round 4: Ch 1. *Sc in next 2 sts, inc in next st; rep from * 5 more times. (24 sts)
5. Round 5: *Sc in next 3 sts, inc; rep from * 5 more times. (30 sts)
6. Round 6: *Sc in next 4 sts, inc; rep from * 5 more times. (36 sts)
7. Round 7: *Sc in next 5 sts, inc; rep from * 5 more times. (42 sts)
8. Round 8: *Sc in next 6 sts, inc; rep from * 5 more times. (48 sts)
9. Round 9: *Sc in next 7 sts, inc; rep from * 5 more times. (54 sts)
10. Join with sl st, fasten off, and weave in the ends.

Check: each round adds 6 stitches, so round 9 has 6 x 9 = 54 stitches. If it curls up like a bowl, you need more increases. If it ruffles, you have too many.

Project 3: Easy Scarf

Materials: about 200 to 250 yards (180 to 230 m) of bulky weight yarn, 6.5 mm (US K-10.5) hook. **Gauge:** 10 hdc and 7 rows = 4 inches (10 cm). **Finished size:** about 6 inches (15 cm) wide and 56 inches (142 cm) long.

1. Chain 17.
2. Row 1: Hdc in 3rd ch from hook and in each ch across. (15 hdc)
3. Rows 2 to 98: Ch 2 (does not count), turn. Hdc in each st across. (15 hdc)
4. Check: 15 hdc at 10 per 4 inches is 6 inches wide, and 98 rows at 7 rows per 4 inches is 56 inches long (98 / 7 x 4 = 56).
5. Fasten off and weave in the ends.

Add fringe by cutting 10-inch (25 cm) lengths of yarn, folding them in half, and pulling the loop through an end stitch with your hook. Trim the fringe even.

Project 4: Simple Beanie

Materials: about 150 yards (137 m) of worsted weight yarn, 5.5 mm (US I-9) hook, stitch marker. **Gauge:** 13 hdc and 10 rounds = 4 inches (10 cm). **Fits:** an adult head about 22 inches (56 cm) around. **Finished size:** about 19.7 inches (50 cm) around and 8 inches (20 cm) tall.

1. Round 1: Make a magic ring. Ch 2 (does not count). Work 8 hdc into the ring. Join with sl st to the first hdc. (8 sts)
2. Round 2: Ch 2. Inc in each st around. (16 sts)
3. Round 3: Ch 2. *Hdc in next st, inc; rep from * 7 more times. (24 sts)
4. Round 4: *Hdc in next 2 sts, inc; rep from * 7 more times. (32 sts)
5. Round 5: *Hdc in next 3 sts, inc; rep from * 7 more times. (40 sts)
6. Round 6: *Hdc in next 4 sts, inc; rep from * 7 more times. (48 sts)
7. Round 7: *Hdc in next 5 sts, inc; rep from * 7 more times. (56 sts)
8. Round 8: *Hdc in next 6 sts, inc; rep from * 7 more times. (64 sts)
9. Rounds 9 to 20: Ch 2. Hdc in each st around, join with sl st. (64 sts)
10. Fasten off and weave in the ends.

Check: round n has 8 x n stitches up to round 8, which is 64. At 13 hdc per 4 inches, 64 stitches measure 64 / 13 x 4 = 19.7 inches. The 20 rounds are 8 crown rounds (about 3.2 inches) plus 12 body rounds (about 4.8 inches), for 8 inches in all. For a deeper brim, add rounds. For a folded brim, make 4 to 6 extra rounds.

Project 5: Stretchy Headband

Materials: about 50 yards (46 m) of worsted weight yarn, 5.5 mm (US I-9) hook, tapestry needle. **Gauge:** 13 hdc and 10 rows = 4 inches (10 cm). **Finished size:** about 4 inches (10 cm) wide and 19 inches (48 cm) around.

1. Chain 15.
2. Row 1: Hdc in 3rd ch from hook and in each ch across. (13 hdc)
3. Rows 2 to 48: Ch 2 (does not count), turn. Hdc in each st across. (13 hdc)
4. Check: 13 hdc at 13 per 4 inches is 4 inches wide, and 48 rows at 10 rows per 4 inches is 19.2 inches long.
5. Bring the short ends together and join with a slip stitch seam or whip stitch. Weave in the ends.

Because the headband is a bit smaller than most heads, it stretches for a snug fit. To make it larger, add rows (2.5 rows per inch). To twist the band at the front, give it a half twist before seaming.

Project 6: Baby Blanket

Materials: about 600 to 700 yards (550 to 640 m) of soft worsted weight yarn (buy about 750 yards to be safe), 5.5 mm (US I-9) hook. **Gauge:** 13 dc and 7 rows = 4 inches (10 cm). **Finished size:** about 31 x 37 inches (79 x 94 cm) with the border.

1. Chain 99.
2. Row 1: Dc in 4th ch from hook and in each ch across. (97 dc)

3. Rows 2 to 63: Ch 3 (counts as first dc), turn. Skip first st, dc in each st across, ending with dc in top of turning ch. (97 dc)
4. Check: 97 dc at 13 per 4 inches is 29.9 inches (about 30), and 63 rows at 7 rows per 4 inches is 36 inches.
5. Border round 1: Do not turn. Ch 1. Sc evenly around, working 3 sc in each corner. Join with sl st.
6. Border round 2: Ch 1. Sc in each st around, working 3 sc in each corner st. Join, fasten off, and weave in the ends.

> **Safe sleep**
>
> A blanket is for supervised play, strollers, and snuggling. Do not leave loose blankets in an infant's sleep space. Follow current safe sleep guidance from your pediatrician.

Project 7: Small Round Basket

Materials: about 100 yards (91 m) of worsted weight cotton, held double (2 strands together), 6.0 mm (US J-10) hook, stitch marker. **Gauge:** 11 sc and 12 rounds = 4 inches (10 cm), with 2 strands held together. **Finished size:** about 6 inches (15 cm) across and 4 inches (10 cm) tall.

1. Round 1: Make a magic ring. Work 6 sc into the ring. (6 sts)
2. Rounds 2 to 9: Increase as in the coaster: round 2 has 12 sts, round 3 has 18, round 4 has 24, round 5 has 30, round 6 has 36, round 7 has 42, round 8 has 48, and round 9 has 54. Work each round as *sc in next (n - 2) sts, inc; rep from * 5 more times. Use a marker to track the start of each spiral round. (54 sts)
3. Round 10: Sc in the back loop only of each st around. This makes the corner. (54 sts)
4. Rounds 11 to 21: Sc in each st around. (54 sts)
5. Sl st in the next st, fasten off, and weave in the ends.
6. Check: 9 base rounds at 12 rounds per 4 inches measures 3 inches from the center to the edge, which is 6 inches across. 12 side rounds (rounds 10 to 21) at 12 per 4 inches gives about 4 inches tall.

Hold two strands for a stiffer fabric. Tight stitches help the basket stand up. Do not put hot items or candles in a basket made of yarn.

Project 8: Classic Granny Square

Materials: about 15 yards (14 m) of worsted weight yarn per square, 5.5 mm (US I-9) hook. **Finished size:** about 4.5 inches (11 cm) square after 4 rounds.

1. Round 1: Make a magic ring. Ch 3 (counts as first dc). Work 2 dc into the ring, ch 2, *3 dc into the ring, ch 2; rep from * 2 more times. Join with sl st to the top of the ch 3. (4 groups of 3 dc, 4 ch-2 corners, 12 dc)
2. Round 2: Sl st across to the next ch-2 corner. Ch 3, 2 dc in the same corner, ch 2, 3 dc in the same corner. Ch 1. *(3 dc, ch 2, 3 dc) in next corner, ch 1; rep from * 2 more times. Join. (24 dc, 4 ch-1 spaces)
3. Round 3: Sl st to the next corner. Ch 3, (2 dc, ch 2, 3 dc) in the corner. Ch 1. *3 dc in the next ch-1 space, ch 1, (3 dc, ch 2, 3 dc) in next corner, ch 1; rep from * 2 more times, then 3 dc in the last ch-1 space, ch 1. Join. (36 dc)
4. Round 4: Sl st to the corner. Ch 3, (2 dc, ch 2, 3 dc) in the corner. Ch 1. *3 dc in each ch-1 space along the side, ch 1 between groups, then (3 dc, ch 2, 3 dc) in the next corner, ch 1; rep from * 2 more times, then 3

dc in each ch-1 space on the last side. Join and fasten off. (48 dc)

5. Check: each corner has 6 dc (4 x 6 = 24). Each side adds one 3-dc group per round after round 2. Round 3 has 4 side groups (12 dc), so 24 + 12 = 36. Round 4 has 8 side groups (24 dc), so 24 + 24 = 48.

Joining granny squares

- **Slip stitch seam:** hold two squares with right sides together and slip stitch through the back loops. Quick and neat.
- **Whip stitch seam:** sew through the back loops of both squares with a tapestry needle. Makes a flat seam.
- **Join-as-you-go:** on the last round, join the corner of the current square to the corner of a finished square with a slip stitch, then continue the round, slip stitching into the matching spaces of the neighbor.

As a plan, 20 squares of 4.5 inches make a lap blanket of 5 squares across and 4 squares down: 5 x 4.5 = 22.5 inches wide and 4 x 4.5 = 18 inches long. Add a border of two rounds of sc for a polished finish. If you sell what you make, check the rules of the market or craft fair where you sell.

23. Troubleshooting

PROBLEM	LIKELY CAUSE	WHAT TO DO
Fabric is stiff and tight	Hook too small or tension too tight	Go up a hook size and relax your hold
Fabric is floppy with holes	Hook too large or tension too loose	Go down a hook size
Edges slope or curve	Missed or extra stitch at the edge	Count every row and work into the turning chain correctly
Piece cups or curls in the round	Too few increases	Add stitches to the increase round and stagger them
Piece ruffles in the round	Too many increases	Remove increases, or frog back a round
Gaps in the first row	Chains too loose	Use a smaller hook for the foundation chain only
Foundation chain is too tight	Chains pulled too snug	Use a larger hook for the foundation chain
Yarn splits	Sharp hook point or splitty yarn	Switch to a smoother hook or plied yarn
Stitches are hard to find	Dark or fuzzy yarn	Use light, smooth yarn while learning
Hands or wrists ache	Gripping too tight	Relax your grip, take breaks, try an ergonomic hook
Colors bleed when washed	Dye is not colorfast	Test a swatch in water before using a dark and a light yarn together

24. Your 14-Day Practice Plan

Spend 20 to 30 minutes a day. Keep every swatch in a basket so you can see your progress on day 14.

DAY	FOCUS	GOAL
1	Hold the hook and yarn, make a slip knot, chain	Chain 30 evenly, then rip back and repeat
2	Chains and slip stitch	Slip stitch across a chain of 20
3	Single crochet	One row of 20 sc
4	Single crochet rows	Work 10 rows of 20 sc and count each row
5	Half double crochet	Chain 22, then work 6 rows of 20 hdc
6	Double crochet	Chain 22, then work 6 rows of 20 dc
7	Review and gauge	Swatch 14 sc and 16 rows, then measure
8	Reading patterns, increases, and decreases	Read the abbreviations table and work sc2tog in a row
9	Magic ring and rounds	Make the first 4 rounds of the coaster (24 sts)
10	Back loop only and color changes	Work 8 rows of BLO sc and change colors every 2 rows
11	Dishcloth	Chain 29 and work 32 rows of 28 sc
12	Coaster	Finish rounds 1 to 9 (54 sts)
13	Granny square	Make one 4-round granny square (48 dc)
14	Choose your first big project	Start the scarf, headband, or beanie, and enjoy

Next step

You now have the stitches, the pattern language, and eight projects to try. Start with your 14-day plan, keep your swatches, and move to a project that excites you. As your confidence grows, return to the stitch library and use those patterns to design scarves and blankets of your own. The more you crochet, the more even your stitches will become.

YOUR FIRST WEEK CHECKLIST

- ☐ Gather a worsted weight yarn and a 5.5 mm (US I-9) hook.
- ☐ Practice the slip knot and chain until they feel natural.
- ☐ Learn single crochet, then half double and double crochet.
- ☐ Count your stitches after every row.
- ☐ Make your first dishcloth.